India and Its Neighbourhood

A Strategic Overview of the ‘Neighbourhood First’ Policy

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At the Heart of a Complex and Vital Region

Geographically central, with land borders touching 7 nations and sea borders with 2.

The region is home to nearly a quarter of the world's population, creating shared opportunities and challenges.

A shared geography, from the Himalayas to the Indian Ocean, dictates security, resource management, and ecological interdependence.

India's land border spans 15,106.7 km; its coastline is 7,516.6 km.

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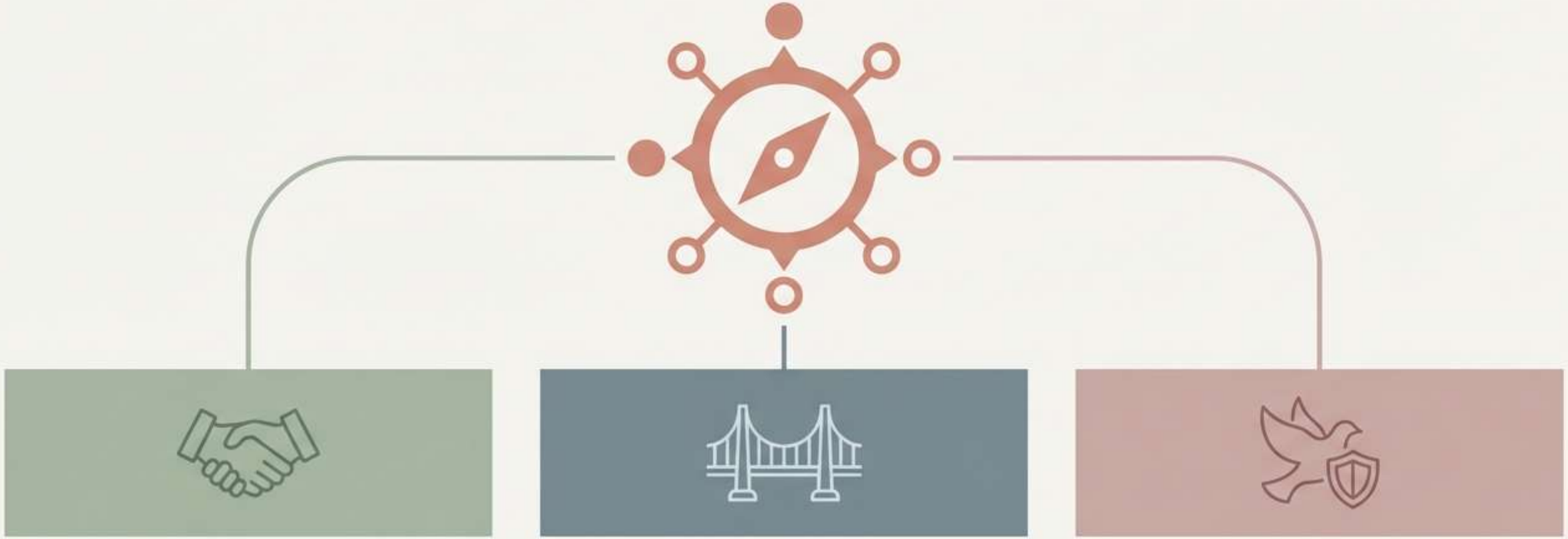
The Guiding Philosophy: ‘Neighbourhood First’ (2014)



Mutual Benefit & Respect

Focus on collaborative, people-centered regional frameworks for peace, prosperity, and sovereign equality.

Enhanced Connectivity

Driving regional integration through transport, energy, digital links, and trade facilitation.

Regional Peace & Stability

Proactive engagement to resolve disputes, address shared challenges like terrorism, and foster cooperation.

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Navigating a Landscape of Complex Challenges

Border Disputes

Unresolved boundaries, notably the 3,488 km Line of Actual Control (LAC) with China and the Line of Control with Pakistan.

Cross-Border Terrorism

A persistent threat to security, with its primary source being groups based in Pakistan.

China's Growing Influence

Strategic competition via initiatives like the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), which includes most neighboring countries except Bhutan.

Regional Instability

Internal political shifts in neighboring countries, such as the 2021 military coup in Myanmar, which directly impact regional stability.

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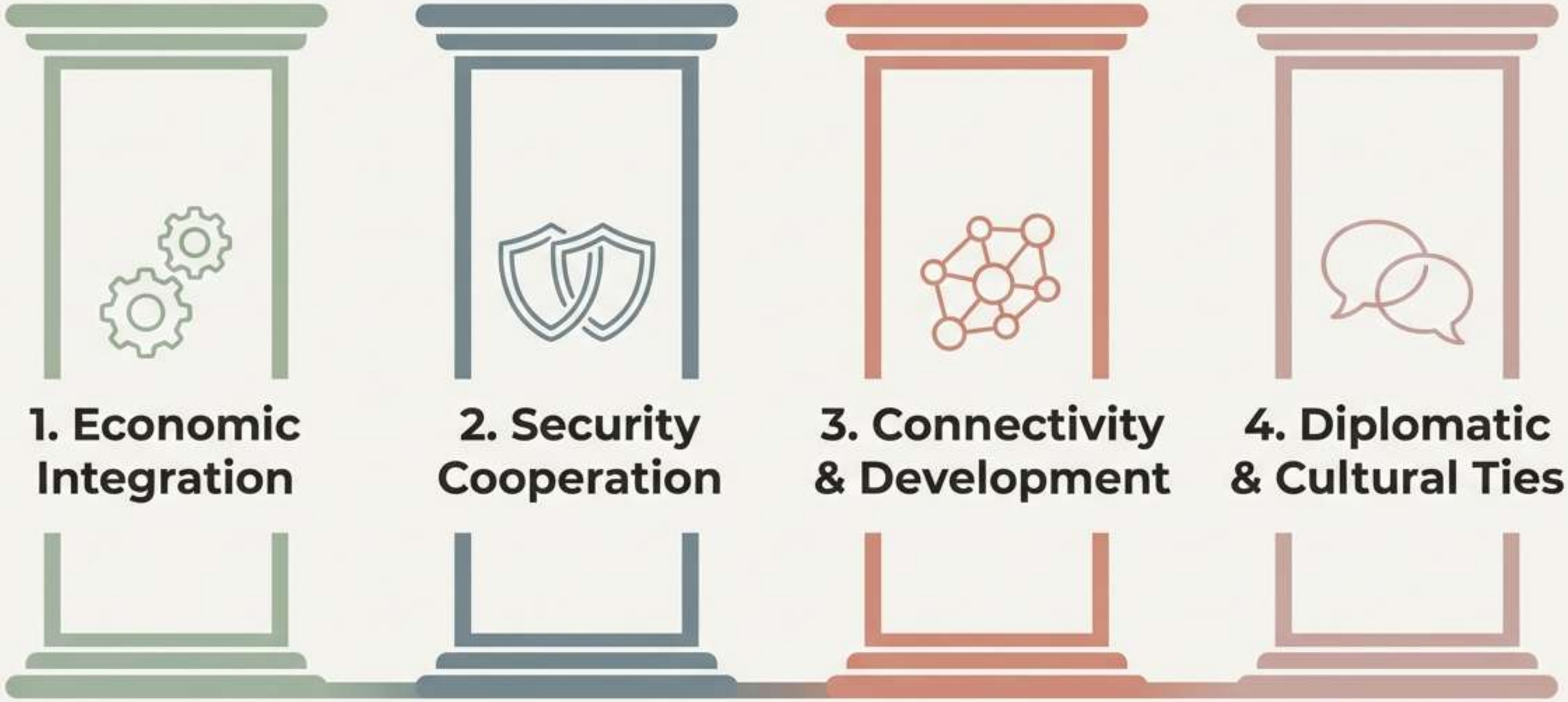
A Multi-Pronged Approach to Regional Engagement



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Pillar in Action: Weaving a Fabric of Shared Prosperity

India-Sri Lanka Free Trade Agreement (ISFTA)

In effect since March 2000, a foundational bilateral trade pact.

SAARC Preferential Trading Arrangement (SAPTA)

Signed in 1993, this agreement laid the groundwork for broader regional trade.

BBIN Motor Vehicle Agreement

Signed in 2015 between Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, and Nepal to ease the transit of passenger and cargo vehicles.

Border Haats (India-Bangladesh)

Local markets at the border designed to boost local economies and people-to-people connections.

Key Stat: South Asia's intra-regional trade is the lowest globally, constituting only 5% of the region's total trade—a significant opportunity for growth.

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Building a Secure and Stable Neighbourhood

Joint Military Exercises

- Mitra Shakti (with Sri Lanka)
- Surya Kiran (with Nepal)
- SAMPRITI (with Bangladesh)

Maritime Security

- SLINEX (Joint Naval Exercise with Sri Lanka)
- Coordinated patrols and surveillance with partners like Sri Lanka and Maldives to secure the Indian Ocean.

Humanitarian Assistance & Disaster Relief (HADR)

- PANEX-21 (HADR Exercise with BIMSTEC nations)
- Operation Insaniyat (Humanitarian assistance provided to Bangladesh during the Rohingya crisis).

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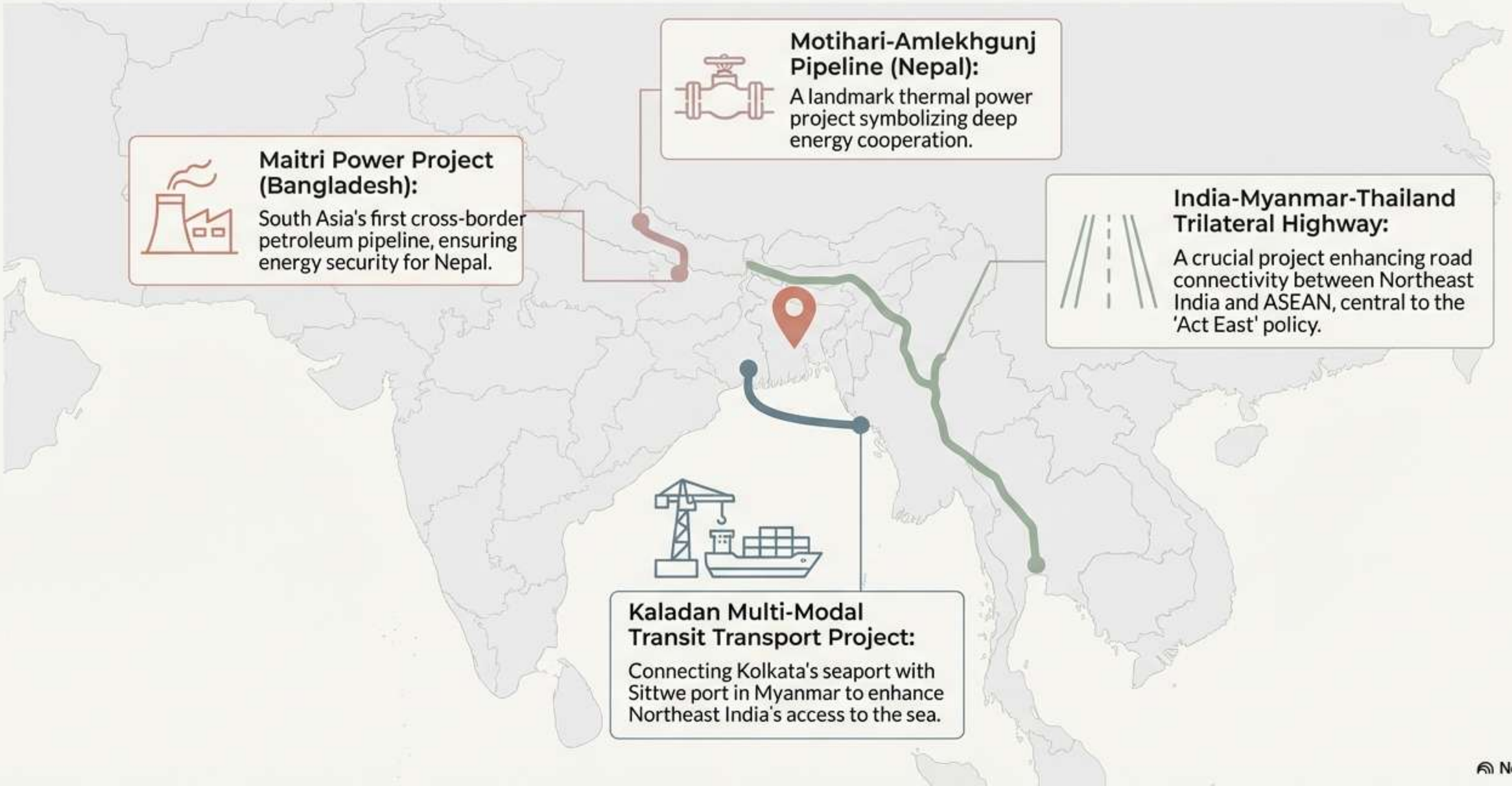
Fostering Growth Through Strategic Infrastructure



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The Western Flank: A Focus on Security and Stability

Pakistan

A relationship defined by historical disputes and conflict.

The Line of Control (LOC) is one of the world's most militarized borders.

The 1972 Simla Agreement established the principle of peaceful, bilateral resolution of all issues.

Afghanistan

A historic development partner.

India funded major infrastructure like the Parliament building and the Salma Dam.

While development partnership is currently paused, focus remains on providing humanitarian support.

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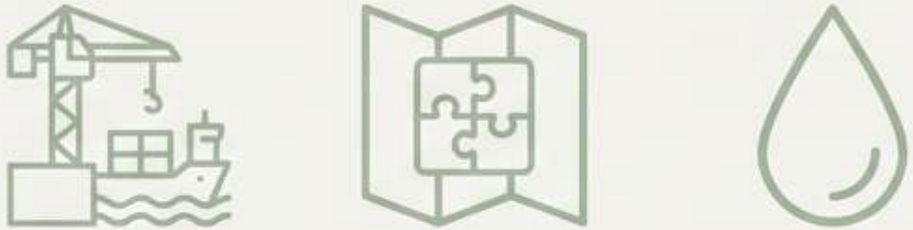
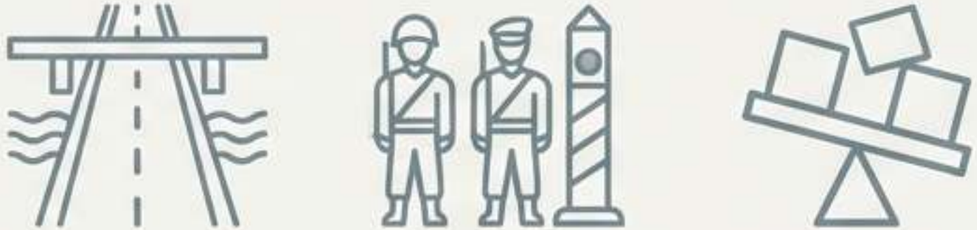
The Eastern Flank: Connectivity and Cooperation

Bangladesh



India shares its longest land border (4,096.7 km) with Bangladesh. The partnership was significantly strengthened by the 2015 Land Boundary Agreement, which resolved long-standing enclave issues. Cooperation extends extends to trade, connectivity, and management of shared rivers.

Myanmar



A crucial gateway to Southeast Asia and central to India's 'Act East' policy. The relationship is balanced between strategic connectivity projects and managing security challenges along the border, complicated by internal political instability.

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Deep Ties in the Himalayas and the Indian Ocean

Nepal

A unique relationship characterized by an open border allowing free movement of people, deep cultural ties, and vital hydropower cooperation.

Bhutan

A special relationship anchored in the 1949 Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation, with India serving as a key partner in security and development.

Sri Lanka

A key maritime partner. India provided crucial financial and material support to Sri Lanka during its 2022 economic crisis.

Maldives

A critical security partner for maritime domain awareness in the Indian Ocean, involving defence cooperation, hydrography, and HADR.

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The Overarching Factor: A Duality of Competition and Coexistence

Competition

Border Tensions: Protracted stand-offs and disputes along the Line of Actual Control (LAC).

Strategic Influence: China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) creates economic and strategic influence across the region.

Coexistence

Economic Interdependence: China remains one of India's largest trading partners.

Multilateral Engagement: Cooperation within forums like BRICS and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) on shared interests.

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The Way Forward: Principles for a Prosperous Future

Core Principles (Gujral Doctrine)

Non-Reciprocity

No Territory Use Against Others

Non-Interference

Respect Sovereignty

Peaceful Dispute Resolution

1. **Non-Reciprocity:** With smaller neighbors, India should give what it can in good faith without insisting on reciprocity.
2. **No Territory Use Against Others:** No South Asian country should allow its territory to be used against the interest of another.
3. **Non-Interference:** Respect for the internal affairs of other nations.
4. **Respect Sovereignty:** Upholding the territorial integrity and sovereignty of all neighbors.
5. **Peaceful Dispute Resolution:** Committing to resolving all disputes through peaceful bilateral negotiations.

Strategic Imperatives

Strengthen platforms like BIMSTEC for regional cooperation.

Accelerate connectivity projects to drive economic interdependence.

Invest in people-to-people exchanges leveraging shared culture and history.

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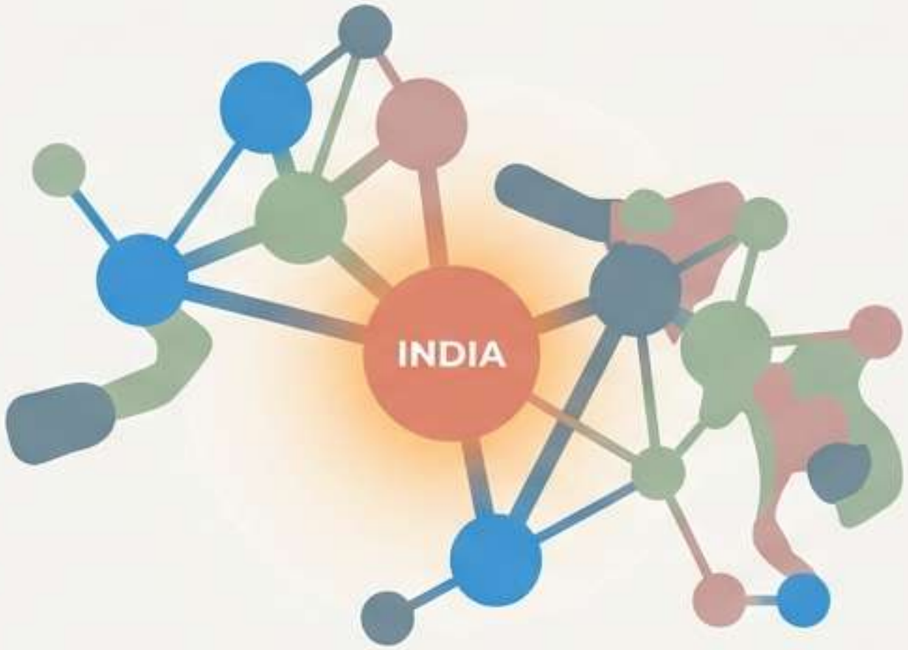
Forging a Future of Shared Prosperity



India's 'Neighbourhood First' policy is a dynamic and adaptive strategy aimed at building a secure, stable, and prosperous South Asia. It is a commitment to developing mutually beneficial, people-centered regional frameworks anchored in the principles of mutual respect and collaborative growth.

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Thank You

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